11. Tibet and China: A Complex and Contested Relationship

In the previous chapters we have seen how China's world view has been influenced by its interactions with the peoples inhabiting its periphery. The settled populations in the river plains of northern China were frequently raided and ravaged by the pastoral tribes ranging across the vast grasslands on China's north and west.

The Tibetan tribes in the west once ruled over a vast empire, and even the powerful Tang dynasty was threatened by Tibet between the seventh and ninth centuries CE before peace was established and borders defined in treaties that are inscribed on pillars that may still be seen today in Lhasa, the Tibetan capital. Was this the beginning of a political merger, as the Chinese would have it, or the recognition of two independent and equal entities, as the Tibetans describe it? This contested view of history is at the heart of the Tibetan question.

China's relationship with Tibet through the centuries has been complex, ambiguous and contested. Just as China went through periods of consolidation and fragmentation, so did Tibet. It is important to understand this relationship because it impinges directly on India–China relations. Chinese claims on Indian territory are derived from a certain Chinese interpretation of its historical links with Tibet, even though it never exercised direct rule over Tibet.

The Tang empire ruled over an extensive territory from its capital at Changan from the seventh to the tenth centuries. In the seventh century, Tibet too became a powerful empire under its greatest king, Srongtsen Gampo (he may have reigned from 629 CE to 649 CE), and threatened the Tang, attacking and occupying large territories in China's western regions. The Tibetans also subdued Nepal to their south. In the peace terms imposed by Srongtsen Gampo, a Chinese princess, Wencheng, was given in marriage